12 Political Divisions of North-East India

Topics covered

- Table of Information
- Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Meghalaya

Using the map here write the names of the seven hill states in the north-east part of India. Start from Sikkim and go in a clockwise direction

S.....

A.....

N.....

M.....

M.....

T.....

M.....

You have already learnt about one state, Assam that is in this region. It is a state of flat lands. The other seven north-eastern states are hill states. They are similar yet different. The states are hilly but some of them also have plains. Some states have mountainous regions. All the states get heavy rain. Read the table for a quick glimpse of information about these states.

State	Capital and some cities	Rivers	Natural vegetation	Crops	Occupation
Sikkim	Gangtok—capital Singtam, Rangpo	Tista Rangit, Lhonak	Forests, orchids, ferns, bamboo	Corn, rice, barley, fruit, vegetables, cardamom, tea	Farming, cattle rearing, scroll painting, handicrafts

State	Capital and some cities	Rivers	Natural vegetation	Crops	Occupation
Arunachal Pradesh	Itanagar—capital Tawang	Dihang, Lohit, Dibang	Forests, swamp forests, medicinal plants and trees	Corn, rice, chillies, fruit, spices	Farming, small-scale industries, silk production
Nagaland	Kohima—capital Dimapur	Doyang, Dikhu Barak, Chindwin	Evergreen forests with mahogany trees, palm and bamboo	Rice, corn, potato, tobacco, sugar cane	Farming, paper making, textiles, **molasses** making
Manipur	Imphal—capital Thoubal, Kakching	Loktak Lake, Manipur	Hilly forests, bamboo, flowers	Rice, corn, sugar cane, mustard, chillies, tobacco, fruit, pulses	Farming, fishing, soap making, carpentry
Mizoram	Aizawl—capital Lunglei, Champhai	Kaladan, Tlawng, Tuirail	Evergreen forests and bamboo	Rice, corn, cotton, vegetables, ginger	Farming, sericulture, handloom, handicrafts, furniture making, ginger products
Tripura	Agartala—capital, Dharmapuri	Gomti, smaller rivers	Forests, marshy plains and bamboo	Rice, cotton, jackfruit, rubber, tea, jute	Agriculture, jute products, textiles, cane and bamboo products, fish farming, cotton garments
Meghalaya	Shillong—capital Mawlai, Tura	Daring and Umkhri	Lush forests and bamboo trees	Rice, corn, betel nuts, chillies, millets, jute, ginger and fruit	Agriculture and small factories that make cement and wood products

SIKKIM

Capital and other cities: Gangtok is the capital city which has the maximum people. Other towns are Singtam and Rangpo.

Rivers: Sikkim is drained by the river Tista before it enters the plains of India. In Sikkim, the Tista is joined

Sikkim has over 200 Buddhist monasteries. This is the well-known Rumtek Monastery.

by the beautiful green Rangit River. The Lhonak, another tributary of the Tista, also flows through the state.

A yak on the banks of the Tsongmo Lake—yaks are found in high snowy regions and are useful for their wool and milk.

Natural vegetation: The state has large areas of forest lands. Sal trees, bamboo, ferns and orchids are found in the lower regions. As the height of the land increases, the vegetation changes to conifers, as well as trees and plants that can grow in colder and higher regions.

Crops: Corn, rice and barley are grown on terraced fields. Fruit, vegetables and tea are also grown. The state also grows large amounts of cardamom.

Occupation: Farming and cattle rearing are the main occupations. Handicrafts, textiles and **scroll painting** are other activities.

ARUNACHAL PRADESH

The largest variety of orchid flowers grows in Arunachal Pradesh. Tipi has an orchid centre where hundreds of types of orchids are grown.

Capital and other cities: Itanagar is the capital city at the foothills of the Himalayas. It is well developed and has the most people living there. Tawang, another town, is a Buddhist centre and has an important monastery by the same name.

Rivers: The Brahmaputra enters India through Arunachal Pradesh. It is called Dihang here and is fast flowing because of the mountainous land. Two big tributaries of the Dihang, the Lohit and Dibang, also flow through the state.

Natural vegetation: About two thirds of the state has forests, with a wide belt of **swampy** (wet land) rainforest at the foothills. The various trees that grow, depend on the height of the land. The forests also have a variety of medicinal plants.

Crops: Though agriculture is the main occupation it is difficult because of the uneven land. Farmers practise shifting agriculture or 'jhoom' cultivation. Forests are cleared by burning them to grow crops. After cultivating the land for a few years, it is abandoned so that the soil can become fertile again. Farmers then 'shift'

to another new place to repeat this cycle again. Corn, rice, fruit and spices like ginger and chillies are grown.

Occupation: Farming is the main occupation. Other small-scale industries like basket weaving, fruit processing, oil milling and silk production are also developing.

Corn is an important part of the diet. Here it is put out to dry before being made into different dishes.

NAGALAND

Capital and other cities: This mountainous state has very few large towns, with Kohima being its capital. Dimapur is another important town. As it is a tribal state, most people live with their tribes in villages. Each tribe has its own language, leader and set of rules. However, English is the official language.

Thousands of Amur falcons travel through Nagaland from north-east China to South Africa. The people protect the birds when they stop to rest and feed. (Inset) An Amur falcon

Rivers: The two rivers, Doyang and Dikhu, create deep valleys. The Barak and Chindwin, flow through the different parts of the state.

Natural vegetation: The forest region has evergreen trees like palm, bamboo and mahogany. Mahogany has a deep red colour and is widely used for making furniture. Jhoom cultivation has made many parts of the land infertile. This is because farmers return to the cleared land too soon, before the natural vegetation has had time to grow back and make the land fertile again.

Crops: Rice, sugar cane, corn, potato and tobacco are the main crops. Farmers use traditional implements like dao (a heavy knife).

Occupation: Farming, paper and furniture making, textile weaving, **molasses** making (molasses=thick brown liquid obtained while refining sugar cane juice) are some of the occupations.

Colourful shawls with interesting designs are woven in Nagaland. Each tribe has its own design!

MANIPUR

Capital and other cities: The state whose name means 'land of gems' has Imphal as its capital. Thoubal and Kakching are other towns with a population of over 10,000 people.

Rivers: The Loktak Lake, the largest freshwater lake in north-east India, is the main source of water. The Manipur River has its source from this lake.

Natural vegetation: The hilly forests have teak and bamboo trees. The lower lands also have many varieties of flowers.

Crops: Rice, corn, sugar cane, mustard, tobacco, chillies, fruit and pulses are grown on terraced fields.

Islands on the Loktak Lake which also has the Keibul Lamjao National Park, a floating park

Occupation: Farming, fishing, silk farming, carpentry, soap making are all important occupations.

The bhut jolokia or ghost pepper chilli that grows in the north-east is one of the hottest in the world!

MIZORAM

Capital and other cities: Aizawl, the capital, is the only large city in the state. Other towns are Lunglei in the east and Champhai in the south with very low populations. Like the other hill states of this region, there are no railways, so towns and villages are connected through roads.

Rivers: The Kaladan and its tributaries flow southwards through the ridges and valleys between the hills. The Tlawng and Tuirail flow northwards.

Aizawl city on top of a hill—most villages in Mizoram are also on top of hills with the chief's house usually in the centre.

Natural vegetation: Thick evergreen forests with champak, ironwood, and gurjun trees are found in most parts of the land. Bamboo is also found in plenty.

Crops: Rice, corn, cotton, vegetables are the main crops grown either through terrace or jhoom cultivation. Ginger is also widely grown.

Dancing in and out of moving bamboos—a very interesting and special dance of this region

Occupation: Farming, **sericulture** (rearing of silkworms for silk), handlooms and handicrafts, furniture making and making of ginger products are some of the main occupations of the Mizo people.

Discuss

SI

Many of the spices we use in our homes—ginger, chillies, cardamom—are grown in the north-east. How are these used in your home?

Did you Know?

SI

The states of the north-east are connected to India via a thin stretch of land known officially as the Siliguri Corridor and popularly as 'Chicken's Neck'.

TRIPURA

Capital and other cities: Its capital Agartala is near Bangladesh. Most parts of the state jut into Bangladesh. Dharmapuri is a historical town.

Bamboo floating on the Gomti River

Weaving of bamboo goods for sale at a fair

Rivers: Many small rivers flow through the state. The largest is the Gomti that has its source in the eastern hills.

Natural vegetation: The central and northern parts of the state are hilly and under forest cover. Sal trees grow widely here. The rest of the land

is a wet **marshy plain** where bamboo grows very well. Some types of bamboo are found especially in this region.

An adult gibbon with its baby in the Gumti Wildlife Sanctuary in Tripura

Crops: Rice, jute, tea, cotton and rubber are the major crops. Jackfruit is also grown.

Occupation: Agriculture, jute products, fruit canning, soap making, and making of cane and bamboo goods, are the most common occupations. Fish farming is also carried out. The state is known for its cloth-weaving and cotton garments.

MEGHALAYA

Capital and other cities: Shillong is the capital of this beautiful state whose name means 'home of the clouds.' Other towns are Tura and Mawlai. Most people live in villages.

Rivers: Many small streams flow through the land, which is a plateau, creating valleys. Important rivers are the Daring and Umkhri.

Natural vegetation: The state is filled with lush forests of pine, oak, sal and bamboo trees. It rains a lot here so the wet conditions make it easy for these plants to grow well.

A root bridge in Meghalaya—roots of trees are grown into bridges that can withstand the wet weather. Wooden bridges may rot in the rains, but these become stronger.

Crops: Main crops are rice, corn, millets, chillies, ginger, betel nuts, jute and fruit. The crops are grown using jhoom cultivation.

Occupation: Agriculture is the main occupation followed by most people in the state. Some small factories that make cement and wooden boards also employ people.

Mawsynram in Meghalaya, has the highest rainfall in the world. People continue their daily work even though most days are wet.

Think and answer

In what way are these north-eastern states similar to each other?

Values and Life Skills

We live in a country where different people speak different languages and follow different ways of life. It is important for us to be aware and respect all of them.

Learn how to say 'welcome' in the languages spoken in these seven states. Learn about one interesting custom that they follow.

REMEMBER

1. All the states in the north-east are mostly hilly. Some have higher mountains than others.
2. There is a lot of rain, so the land is green.
3. Most states follow jhoom cultivation. Terrace farming is also done in some states.
4. Corn, fruit and spices are important crops.
5. Most people live in villages; there are few large cities.

NEW WORDS

Molasses	a thick black sweet sticky liquid produced when sugar is refined
Scroll painting	painting on silk or paper that is rolled up
Swampy	land that is very wet or covered with water and in which plants, trees, etc. are growing
Sericulture	growing of silkworms to produce silk
Marshy plain	land that is always soft and wet

EXERCISES

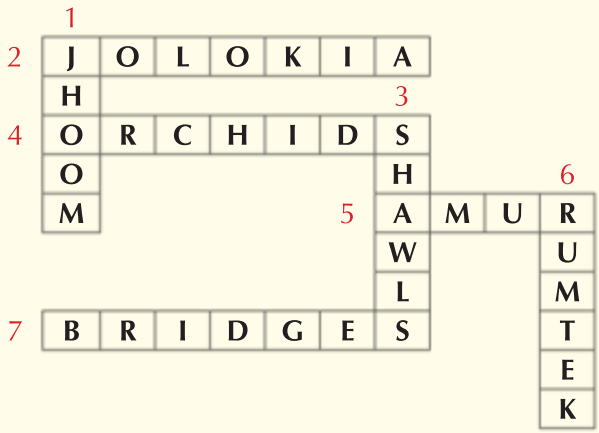
A. The perfect pair

Pick one word from each group to make the correct pair.

Group 1	Group 2	Perfect pair
Nagaland	Gangtok	.....
Manipur	Itanagar	.....
Sikkim	Kohima	.....
Arunachal Pradesh	Shillong	.....
Tripura	Aizawl	.....
Meghalaya	Agartala	.....
Mizoram	Imphal	.....

B. Crossword

Write the clues for the words in this crossword in your notebook.



C. Fill in the blanks.

1. The river ..... flows through Sikkim.
2. The Brahmaputra is called ..... in Arunachal Pradesh.
3. One of the rivers that flows through Nagaland is ..... .
4. The main source of water in Manipur is the ....
5. The most important river in Tripura is ..... .
6. The state whose name means 'home of the clouds' is ..... .
7. Sericulture is an important occupation in ..... .

D. Brain teaser

Unscramble these words to make names of towns in the north-eastern states. Say to which state they belong.

pognra, gunllei, waangt, mapurdi, chiakkgn, banolei, urat

E. Answer the following questions.

1. Why are the states in the north-east so green?
2. What is the difference between jhoom and terrace farming?
3. Name the neighbouring countries the north-eastern states share a border with. (Use the map on page 72 to help you.)
4. What are the common occupations of the people in the north-eastern states?
5. What is sericulture?
6. Why is there a fruit preservation industry in these states?

TP **THINGS TO DO**

SI

A. Picture study

1. Identify the different bamboo-made objects in these pictures.
2. In what other ways is the bamboo plant used?
3. Why is it used in so many different ways?

SI

B. On your own

Make heinou asangba metpa, a Manipuri chutney. Let an adult help you.
You will need: raw green mangoes, some salt and sugar, chopped green chillies, and mint.

1. Peel and grate the mangoes. Add salt and sugar to taste.
2. Add the chopped green chillies and mint and mix well.

C. In a group

1. Do the steps of the bamboo dance with your friends. Instead of bamboos you can draw lines on the floor and dance in and out of the lines.
2. Make seven groups and put together the information on each of these states in your notebook.

WEBLINK

Stone pulling festival of Nagaland: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=shOCqpT75Rg (accessed on 27 July 2017)